BIHAR

NITISH SHOWS WHO'S THE BOSS

By Amitabh Srivastava



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DIVERSION AHEAD? CM Nitish (left) with RJD's Tejashwi Yadav at the iftar party

On April 22, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar dropped in at an iftar gathering at political rival and de facto Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief Tejashwi Yadav's residence. It immediately set off the rumours mills in capital Patna, and conveyed a message to alliance partner BJP, which has been getting increasingly ambitious about a bigger role in Bihar of late.

Nitish's visit—with the media in attendance, he preferred to walk the 100 metres from his 1, Anne Marg bungalow to the former deputy chief minister's home on 10, Circular Road—was portentous as it showcased that he was not without options. Given the assembly seat statistics, the opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and Nitish's Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) have the numbers to form an alternative government were they to band up.

For more than a month now, Patna had been caught up in a strong current of speculation that Nitish would be made to accept a position at the Centre, paving the way for a BJP leader to head the government. With the saffron party doing nothing to dispel the notion, the iftar visit amply demonstrated Nitish's unique advantage in the complex metrics of Bihar politics—the fact that he is acceptable as a leader to both the BJP and the RJD. As a top JD(U) leader scoffed and said, "Nitish Kumar has a legacy and a mandate, which he cannot forfeit just because someone in the BJP wants to take over as the next CM." The legacy part is true—barring the 2014 Lok Sabha election, the winner in every assembly and general election since 2005 has had Bihar's longest-serving CM by their side.

This was the Bihar CM's first visit to Tejashwi's house in the past five years. Nitish and the RJD have been at loggerheads since July 2017 when he unceremoniously dumped the then ally and joined hands with the BJP to form a new government. Cut to now, and relations between Nitish's JD(U) and the BJP have been uneasy since the 2020 assembly election, when the saffron party became the big brother in the alliance (the BJP has 77 seats, the RJD 76 and JD(U) 45 in the 243-member assembly). Things were coming to a head with BJP state president Sanjay Jaiswal causing some heartburn in the JD(U) after his cryptic comments to local journalists when asked whether Nitish would stay CM till 2025. "Who can say what will happen in the future?" Jaiswal said. "Someone could step out now and have an accident...."

BESET BY AN INCREASINGLY AMBITIOUS BJP, NITISH SHOWED HE HAD OPTIONS WITH AN IFTAR VISIT TO THE RJD CAMP

Incidentally, the timing of the iftar visit was also crucial—the day RJD patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav was granted bail in a fodder scam case and just hours before Union home minister Amit Shah's visit to the state the next morning. And in true Nitish style of keeping allies and opponents guessing, he broke tradition by receiving Shah at the Patna airport. The whole episode seemed designed for one goal—deflate an otherwise belligerent state BJP.

Shah, too, seemed to confirm this when he spoke at Jagdishpur in Bhojpur on April 23, emphasising how the NDA government led by Nitish had steered Bihar toward development. Round 1 of the bout is over, and the Bihar CM seems to be leading in points scored. ■